



The Grand Palace

An historic Thai royal palace in Bangkok that houses the revered Emerald Buddha



The Grand Palace in Bangkok is a complex of more than a hundred buildings. It was founded in 1782, when the first king of Thailand's reigning Chakri dynasty, Rama I, established his capital on the east side of the Chao Phraya River. A royal residence, an administrative center, and a site to hold ceremonies, the new palace became a "city within a city," teeming with thousands of officials, soldiers, servants, and concubines. Built over 200 years, the palace's state apartments, halls, and temples exhibit an eclectic mix of traditional Thai architecture and later foreign-influenced styles.

Temple of the Emerald Buddha

Among the many brightly colored, ornate palace buildings, the most famous is *Wat Phra Kaew*, also known as the Temple of the Emerald Buddha. Thailand's most sacred temple, it is named for the small green statue it houses, revered as the protector of the country's safety and prosperity.

The Grand Palace was occupied until 1932, by which time the royal family and government offices had dispersed to other locations. It is now chiefly a tourist attraction.



△ **GUARDIANS OF THE PALACE**
Statues of Yaksha, mythical giant warriors, guard the walls and doors of the Temple of the Emerald Buddha and other buildings in the Grand Palace.

Only the **King of Thailand** is allowed to touch the **Emerald Buddha** in the **palace temple**